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Early Childhood

The Great Afternoon

Cartoons Are for Life: The Secret Password & The Afternoon Sanctuary

Date: 1994-05-18 at 15:30 America/New_York

3:30 PM — The Secret Password

At three-thirty on a weekday afternoon, the upstairs hallway of our house in Virginia Beach was supposed to be quiet, and the only way to keep the outside world from following us inside was to lock the perimeter behind a password.

Inside my deep-blue bedroom, I sat cross-legged on the dark low-pile carpet in front of the television stand, watching the red digital clock on the cable converter box tick from 3:28 to 3:29. Having just turned nine years old back on April eighth, I didn't care what the other kids on our street were doing after the school bus dropped us off. School was six straight hours of scraping desks, unpredictable bells, and teachers who tried to seat fraternal twins on opposite sides of the hallway just because I was a boy and Katie was a girl.

By the time our sneakers hit the front porch, both of us needed the exact same reset.

Right on the dot at 3:29, three polite, measured knocks sounded against the painted wood of my closed bedroom door.

I didn't reach for the brass doorknob yet. I stayed right where I was on the carpet, keeping to the rules of our protocol.

"Cartoons are for life," came Katie's voice through the wood, hushed and completely serious.

The secret password was given. Immediately, I scrambled up off the carpet and swung the door open to admit my twin sister just in time for our favorite afternoon block of cartoons. To the teachers at school and the adults in our extended family, I was Nathaniel, though Dad and Katie half the time just called me Nate; behind this door, I was simply the other half of Katie's perimeter.

Katie slipped inside, her long, straight platinum-blonde hair swinging past her shoulders as she pulled the door shut behind her until the latch clicked. We didn't need to explain to anyone else why we had a password for a room ten feet away from her own bedroom down the hall. Out in the rest of the house, the afternoon air was already heavy—Mom had locked her bedroom door at two o'clock with another headache and a glass from the kitchen cabinet, and Dad wouldn't be home from work until five-thirty to start dinner. Behind my closed door, however, the rules belonged entirely to the two of us.

I rushed back across the carpet and pressed the power button on the front of the television and the cable converter box just as the Majestic Studios castle logo and the afternoon cartoon block bumper flashed across the curved glass tube.

The opening brass fanfare of the *Galactic Samurai Geckos* theme song burst out of the small speaker grille, and instantly, both of us got completely carried away. Katie grabbed both of my hands, and for the next sixty seconds we bounced on the balls of our feet in the middle of the carpet, belting out every single word of the intro theme in unison while the animated title cards rolled across the screen.

Then, just as quickly, the final drumbeat of the opening theme faded out, the episode title card appeared, and the two of us were brought gently back to earth.

Without letting go of my hand, Katie dropped down onto the carpet right beside me, leaning her shoulder firmly against mine. I adjusted the volume knob down two notches so the dialogue wouldn't echo into the hallway, rested my back against the side of my bed frame, and let my sister's weight anchor me in place while the afternoon cartoons glowed across the quiet room.

Summer Camp at Virginia Dominion University

The Parallel Pair: Dominion Mall & The VDU Fieldhouse

Date: 1994-07-12 at 08:45 America/New_York

8:45 AM — Two Pairs on Dominion Mall

When Dad signed Katie and me up for the two-week, all-day block at the Virginia Dominion University Junior Admirals Summer Camp in Norfolk—running from nine o'clock in the morning until four o'clock in the afternoon—he had one simple goal: keeping the two of us safely out of the house during the middle of July while he was at work.

Katie and I had our own goal, and it was even simpler: we were not letting go of each other.

Standing on the wide, sun-bleached concrete plaza of Dominion Mall at eight-forty-five in the morning, wearing matching royal-blue VDU Summer Camp t-shirts over our shorts, Katie had her fingers wrapped tightly around my right wrist. The humid breeze coming off the Elizabeth River carried the roar of Hampton Boulevard traffic and the loud splash of the circular concrete plaza fountain, and fifteen unfamiliar kids were chattering all around us. Whenever a crowd got that loud, Katie's hand locked onto my arm, and my shoulder stayed angled right beside hers to block out the static.

Two paces ahead of us in the Youth Division line, I noticed we weren't the only brother and sister operating on that exact rule.

A nine-year-old boy with reddish-blond hair and wire-rimmed glasses—whose name tag read *Michael*—and his seven-year-old sister *Rachel*, who had dark shoulder-length hair and glasses of her own, were standing hip-to-hip with their fingers laced together in a white-knuckled grip while their fourteen-year-old sister adjusted her backpack beside them before heading over to the Senior Division group. Just like Katie and me, Michael and Rachel didn't care about the cartoons or baseball cards the other campers were shouting about; they were holding onto each other like their lives depended on it.

Naturally, the two college-age counselors running our Youth Division—Counselor Brad and Counselor Kelly—looked at the four of us and reached the exact wrong conclusion.

"All right, Youth Division, let's buddy up in two lines for the walk across Dominion Mall!" Brad announced over the rush of the fountain, tapping his wooden clipboard with a grin. "Look at this—we've got two brothers and two sisters right next to each other! Let's mix it up today so the boys can hang out with the boys and the girls can hang out with the girls! Michael, step right back here and pair up with Nathaniel! And Rachel, you team up with Katie!"

Before I could protest, Brad guided me a step forward beside Michael, while Kelly gently steered Katie two steps back beside Rachel.

For four seconds, the counselors' geometry held.

I looked sideways at Michael through the thick Tidewater humidity. Michael looked sideways at me behind his wire-rimmed glasses. Neither of us had anything against the other—in fact, I could tell in half a heartbeat that his brain hated the sudden change in the line just as much as mine did. Behind us, Katie wasn't saying a word to Rachel, and Rachel wasn't saying a word to Katie; both of our sisters were staring straight at the backs of our blue camp shirts with their shoulders stiff and their jaws locked tight.

Michael and I didn't need to say a single word out loud. As soon as Counselor Brad turned his back and held his clipboard up in the air to lead the group across the light-gray concrete squares of Dominion Mall, Michael gave me a tiny, solemn nod, and I nodded right back.

I stepped half a pace to my left. Michael stepped half a pace to his right. In the exact same motion, Katie slipped forward to grab my hand again, and Rachel stepped right back into place on Michael's left flank.

By the time our sneakers clicked across the second concrete expansion joint past the circular fountain toward the precast-concrete and blue-glass facade of the University Library, the boy-and-girl experiment was completely over. It was brother and sister on the left, and twin brother and twin sister on the right.

9:30 AM — Terminal 4 and Terminal 5

At nine-thirty, the counselors ushered us out of the ninety-degree heat into the sixty-eight-degree air conditioning of the university computer lab.

Thirty beige desktop towers running *Quantum OS* and curved CRT monitors lined the walls, their cooling fans humming in a low, steady chord behind rows of mechanical *KeyMech* keyboards. I loved computers almost as much as I loved our afternoon cartoons, and Katie loved sitting beside me while we took turns with the mouse and keyboard.

Counselor Brad, however, still hadn't given up on his clipboard chart.

"Okay, campers, listen up!" Brad called out from the front desk, holding up a plastic tray of 3.5-inch floppy disks. "Boys on the left wall row—we've got *Wagon Train West* and *Where on the Map Is Scarlet Devereaux?* loaded up! Girls on the right wall row for *Digit Chompers* and *PixelPaint Junior*!"

Brad pointed Michael to Terminal 4 and guided me into the rolling plastic chair right next to him at Terminal 5. Across the blue carpet, Counselor Kelly led Rachel and Katie to Terminals 19 and 20 against the opposite wall.

The moment Katie's hand left my wrist, the hum of the computer lab stopped feeling calming and started feeling like a trap. Down the row to our left, a boy in a basketball cap was pounding his mechanical spacebar with both thumbs and yelling at the screen as his wagon sank in a river. I didn't touch my keyboard at Terminal 5. Instead, I twisted halfway around in my plastic chair and looked straight across the center aisle.

At Terminal 20, Katie was sitting completely motionless in front of the flashing five-by-five number grid of *Digit Chompers*, twisting the hem of her royal-blue camp shirt around her fingers while looking back across the carpet at me. Right beside her at Terminal 19, Rachel Ragsdale had pulled both hands off her desk and tucked her knuckles tightly against her chest.

Next to me at Terminal 4, Michael pushed his chair back six inches and looked at his sister. At the exact same moment, I tapped the open corner of my desk at Terminal 5 and motioned to Katie.

While Brad was kneeling beside the dot-matrix printer at the front of the room, Katie and Rachel slid off their chairs in perfect synchronization and walked three quiet steps side by side across the carpet.

Rachel squeezed onto the right half of Michael's seat at Terminal 4, and Katie pulled the empty rolling chair from the end of the row right up against my right side at Terminal 5, her long platinum-blonde hair brushing my sleeve as she exhaled a long, quiet breath of relief.

"Hey, girls, your computers are still running over on the right wall—" Counselor Kelly started, walking down the aisle before stopping short as she took in the two identical brother-and-sister teams sitting shoulder-to-shoulder at Terminals 4 and 5.

"She's playing with me," Michael told her quietly from Terminal 4, his left hand resting on the arrow keys while Rachel's right thumb hovered over the spacebar for *Digit Chompers*. "I steer the square, and Rachel chomps the multiples. That's how we play."

I rested my left hand on the keyboard of Terminal 5 and placed Katie's hand over the beige two-button mouse for *Wagon Train West*.

"Katie's my twin," I said, looking up at Kelly with quiet, unshakable certainty. "We always play together."

Kelly looked from Michael and Rachel to Katie and me. Neither pair was making noise, neither pair was arguing, and the panicked stiffness had vanished from all four of us the second the sisters were back beside their brothers. Slowly, Kelly smiled, pulled an extra chair over for Rachel so both pairs had two seats pushed flush together, and jotted a quick note on her clipboard.

"Okay," Kelly said gently. "Michael and Rachel on Terminal 4, Nathaniel and Katie on Terminal 5."

For the next hour and a half, Katie and I guided our pixel wagon all the way across the western rivers without losing a single ox—trading turns with the mouse while Michael and Rachel cleared screen after screen of *Digit Chompers* two feet to our left.

1:30 PM — Pair 1 and Pair 2 at the Fieldhouse Pool

After eating our grilled cheese sandwiches side by side in the Monarch Commons dining hall at noon—just a few seats down from where Michael and Rachel's fourteen-year-old sister Jessica used her written lunch exception on the camp roster to sit with them and quiz them on campus landmarks—our group walked down Hampton Boulevard to the VDU Fieldhouse.

The Fieldhouse was a massive brick athletic building where the Lady Admirals played women's basketball during the school year while the men's team played downtown under the concrete dome of the Norfolk Prism. Down the rubber-floored hallway, through the double doors of the Fieldhouse Natatorium, the indoor swimming pool echoed with splashing water and bouncing whistles.

As soon as I stepped out of the boys' locker room in my swim trunks, Katie stepped out of the girls' locker room door in her navy one-piece swimsuit, walked straight across the wet white tile, and grabbed my hand with both of hers. Right next to us on the bench, Rachel Ragsdale did the exact same thing with Michael.

Up on the deck beside the white plastic Buddy Board, Counselor Brad held up his thick black grease pencil and tried the gender split one last time.

"Every fifteen minutes when the lifeguard blows the long whistle and yells *Buddy Check*, you and your buddy have to find each other in the shallow end, grab hands, and hold them up in the air!" Brad called out over the echoing cavern. "Michael and Nathaniel, you guys are Pair Four! Rachel and Katie, you two are Pair Nine!"

Katie squeezed my fingers tightly as thirty kids splashed into the pool at once. I didn't let go of her hand, and four feet to my left, Michael didn't let go of Rachel's. Together, both pairs walked down the wide fiberglass steps into the warm, three-foot shallow end along the side wall.

Two minutes later, the head lifeguard on the high white chair raised his silver whistle to his lips.

TWEEEEET!

"BUDDY CHECK!" the lifeguard shouted through his red megaphone. "Find your buddy and hands in the air!"

Out in the middle of the shallow end, kids who had been chasing each other in *Admirals and Anchors* pool tag splashed around in circles trying to remember who their assigned partner was.

Along the shallow wall, Katie's left hand was already laced tightly through my right hand, and Rachel's right hand was already laced tightly through Michael's left. Before the whistle had even stopped echoing off the steel roof trusses of the Fieldhouse, all four of us raised our joined hands straight into the air above the water.

Up on the deck, Counselor Brad stared at our two pairs of raised brother-and-sister hands, looked at Counselor Kelly laughing softly behind her clipboard, and finally surrendered. Wiping his rag across the grease pencil on the white plastic board, Brad wrote two new permanent assignments at the very top of the list:

PAIR 1: MICHAEL + RACHEL PAIR 2: NATHANIEL + KATIE

Katie looked at me as we lowered our arms back into the warm water, a bright, triumphant smile breaking across her face, and across the lane Michael and Rachel shared the exact same quiet grin. For the rest of the two-week camp block—from the morning walk across Dominion Mall to afternoon *Four-in-a-Row Grid* and *Wild Draw* cards in the Fieldhouse multipurpose room—nobody at Virginia Dominion University ever tried to separate either pair of siblings again.

Big Family Christmas

The Newport News ARTS Train & The Downstairs Sofa Bed

Date: 1994-12-23 at 18:15 America/New_York

6:15 PM — The Newport News ARTS Platform

The evening train pulled into the brick ARTS—American Rail Transit Service—station in Newport News with a long hiss of air brakes and a cloud of white steam rising into the cold December air.

Up on the concrete platform, Katie and I stood side by side in our winter coats with our hands tucked into our pockets, watching the stainless-steel ARTS passenger doors slide open. Moments later, Grandma, our Aunt Elizabeth, and our nine-year-old cousin Chelsea stepped down onto the platform carrying their holiday suitcases, and the whole family crowded together to exchange hugs and greetings.

True to form, before we had even walked ten feet past the station canopy toward the parking lot, Aunt Elizabeth wasted no time digging into her coat pocket and lighting up a cigarette.

Beside us, Chelsea immediately scowled and angrily plugged her nose with two fingers.

“Mom, that’s gross,” Chelsea stammered, waving a hand in front of her face as all of us were forced to stand on the cold curb waiting before we could load into the vehicles.

“Liz, put that out,” our dad snapped, his breath fogging in the December chill as he hefted two suitcases into the trunk of our Holt sedan. “You know damn well that’s not good for you!”

“Alright, alright,” Aunt Liz snapped back, stubbing the cigarette out on the heel of her boot as we sorted ourselves into the two vehicles for the drive back across the Hampton Roads Bridge-Tunnel.

Chelsea climbed into the middle of the back bench seat of the Holt sedan right between Katie and me, while Dad and Aunt Liz sat up front. Behind us, Mom—who was having a rare sober evening so Grandma wouldn’t ask questions at the ARTS station—drove Grandma in the pickup truck following our taillights down Interstate 64.

As soon as our sedan cleared the tunnel and turned onto the familiar streets of Virginia Beach, Katie leaned forward slightly to look across Chelsea at me, her eyes bright with holiday excitement.

“Welcome to Virginia Beach!” Katie squealed happily, squeezing Chelsea’s mittened hand. “Now, the three of us are going to have to squeeze into one room!”

8:00 PM — Downstairs Sanctuary

When we pulled into the driveway at home, Katie, Chelsea, and I pitched in right away to help Grandma and Aunt Liz carry their overnight bags through the front door.

Standing at the foot of the stairs in the foyer, Dad laid out the holiday room assignments.

“You three will share the sofa bed,” Dad said to us kids, gesturing toward the living room. Turning to the adults, he added, “Mom, Katie’s room is closer to the upstairs bathroom. Liz, you get Nathaniel’s room.”

In a lot of houses, getting evicted from both of our upstairs bedrooms for the holidays would have felt like a punishment. To Katie and me, however, Dad had just handed us the greatest logistical gift of Christmas. With Grandma in Katie’s room, Aunt Liz in my room, and Mom and Dad behind their closed door at the end of the upstairs hall, all four adults were confined to the second floor—which meant the entire first floor belonged exclusively to the three of us kids.

“Chelsea, there’s a bathroom down here we can use,” Katie explained immediately, pointing down the short hallway off the living room. “It has a shower. We can stay downstairs while the adults are upstairs.”

“Okay,” our cousin replied, setting her backpack by the couch. “Where do we sleep?”

“The three of us will sleep down here. This sofa is a sofa bed,” Katie replied proudly as the three of us finished carrying the last of the adults’ bags up the stairs.

Because the train had arrived late in the evening, dinner was fast and simple—warm bowls of soup and buttered rolls around the dining table—and before nine o’clock, the adults retreated upstairs for the night, leaving the first floor completely to the three of us.

“I want to take a shower,” Chelsea announced to Katie and me once the upstairs footsteps quieted down.

Katie walked her down the short hall to show her how to turn the downstairs shower faucet on and where the clean towels were stacked, then came back out into the living room where I had already changed into my long-sleeved flannel pajamas and was busy pulling the heavy metal frame of the sofa bed out from inside the couch. Working together, Katie and I unfolded the mattress, smoothed out the clean cotton sheets, and spread two thick winter quilts across the top.

A few minutes later, the bathroom door clicked open. Instead of putting her pajamas on inside the bathroom, Chelsea wandered straight out into the living room wrapped only in a bath towel, making her way casually toward the sofa bed Katie and I had just finished setting up.

“CHELSEA!” Katie stammered, her hand shooting out in a flash to clamp firmly over my eyes. “Your cousin shouldn’t be seeing all of you!”

Before Chelsea could even blink, Katie spun her right back around by the shoulders and shunted her straight back into the downstairs bathroom to finish drying off and put her flannel pajamas on properly.

“You need to stop blushing,” my twin sister admonished me once the bathroom door clicked shut behind Chelsea—except she didn’t truly admonish me at all, letting out a quiet, bubbly giggle as she took her hand off my face. “You promise not to tell anyone?”

“Promise,” I replied, rubbing the bridge of my nose as we both climbed onto the left side of the wide sofa bed in our flannel pajamas and pulled the heavy winter quilt up to our chins.

“You know Chelsea sometimes forgets the rules when she’s in a different house,” Katie whispered, leaning her head against my shoulder underneath the quilt and lacing her fingers through mine. “As long as we look out for each other down here, nobody upstairs is going to yell at anyone.”

“Not a word to anyone,” I whispered back, squeezing her hand.

Two minutes later, Chelsea came back out of the hallway wearing her full green flannel pajamas, fuzzy socks, and a sheepish grin, and climbed under the quilt on the far side of the sofa bed. With the living room lamp clicked off and only the colored lights of the Christmas tree glowing softly in the corner, Katie stayed tucked right against my side—the two of us holding down our downstairs sanctuary while the winter wind rattled the front windows.

Middle School & The Blizzard of ’96

The Blizzard of ’96

Snow Day in Virginia Beach & The Backyard Promise

Date: 1996-01-06 at 11:30 America/New_York

11:30 AM — Waiting for the First Flakes

In Virginia Beach, real snow was rare enough that the mere rumor of a winter storm was enough to bring our entire street to a standstill.

On the first Saturday of January 1996, Katie and I stood shoulder to shoulder at my upstairs bedroom window, pressing our palms against the cold wooden sill as we stared out at the residential street below. Outside, the air was bitterly cold, and heavy, slate-gray clouds were rolling in off the Atlantic until the sky looked like brushed steel. Behind us on my bedroom stand, the local Norfolk GBS news station had cut into regular Saturday morning programming, the meteorologist standing in front of a swirling radar map warning all of Hampton Roads to prepare for the Blizzard of ’96.

“You think we’re going to have snow?” Katie asked, her breath fogging a small circle on the glass pane.

“Hope so. SNOW DAY!” I said, practically vibrating with excitement as I looked from the heavy sky back to the radar bands on the screen. Even on a Saturday, a real blizzard meant Monday and Tuesday would be wiped clean off the school calendar.

“Snow,” Katie replied hopefully, leaning her shoulder against mine as the news anchor continued to drone on and on about wind gusts, coastal flooding, and how many inches were expected by nightfall.

At twelve-thirty, while Katie and I were sitting side by side at the kitchen table eating our lunch sandwiches, the first white flakes began to drift past the dining room window. At first it wasn’t much—just fine, powdery crystals swirling across the dry grass—but within twenty minutes the flakes grew thick and steady, dusting the wooden fence rails and the roof of Dad’s car.

“Wonder if it will stick,” Katie giggled, pointing her finger toward the patio.

By late afternoon, it didn’t just stick; it buried the entire backyard under a clean, silent blanket of white.

Inside the house, however, the quiet didn’t last. Around five o’clock, the familiar, sharp sound of Mom’s and Dad’s voices started rising from the upstairs hallway—first a slammed cabinet door, then the bitter, overlapping shouting match that always followed whenever Dad found another empty bottle hidden behind the pantry cans.

5:45 PM — The Backyard Bear Hug

Katie and I didn’t wait for the yelling to reach the staircase. We pulled on our heavy winter jackets and boots and slipped out the back door into the twilight snow.

Out in the backyard, inside the perimeter of our white wooden picket fence, the falling snow acted like a giant acoustic blanket over the neighborhood. The streetlamps glowed pale orange through the swirling flakes, and every footstep made a soft, muted crunch under our shoes.

Standing near the center of the yard with the snow settling onto my short blonde hair, the cold wind hit my face, and all at once the weight of everything we had been carrying over the past year caught up with me. My chest tightened, and before I could stop myself, I started sniffling in the cold air.

Katie turned around immediately. She didn't hesitate for a second—she stepped straight through the snow and pulled me into a tight, fierce bear hug, wrapping both of her blue-jacketed arms around my shoulders.

"What's wrong?" Katie asked softly against my ear, holding onto me with all her strength.

"I'm just so happy you're willing to do all of this for me," I whispered into her shoulder, my voice shaking slightly as I held onto the back of her winter coat, unsure of how to put the rest of the knot in my chest into words.

Katie didn't need me to explain it. Because she was my twin, she already knew the exact two things crushing my ribs.

"You're still upset with last year, and that girl everyone thought you had a crush on?" Katie asked gently.

"Yes, I am," I whimpered, burying my face against her collar, overwhelmingly grateful that my twin sister was hugging me instead of telling me to toughen up. All through the previous spring at school, a pack of kids in our grade had latched onto a rumor that I had a crush on a girl in our homeroom, turning every hallway change and cafeteria period into a relentless, mocking gauntlet that wouldn't stop no matter what I said. "And it does not help that Mom and Dad are arguing with each other again. I just want to enjoy the snow without the screaming."

"I'm right here, and I will never leave you," Katie replied fiercely, pulling me into an even tighter bear hug as the heavy January snow came down all around us in the twilight. "I'm your sister, and I would just never, ever leave you."

She held onto me for a long moment in the quiet yard, letting the steady pressure of her arms slow my breathing down, before she spoke again.

"Your classmates are mean," Katie continued, her voice firm against the cold wind. "Especially when they refuse to back down. When we go back to school, I will gladly play my part of pretend girlfriend so they leave you alone."

"Thank you, but I think everyone knows that you're my sister," I whispered, managing a small, shaky laugh even as my teeth started chattering from the twenty-degree air.

"Come on, let's head back inside before we freeze," Katie said, taking my hand and leading me back across the snow-covered grass toward the back door.

Inside the warm kitchen, the shouting upstairs had finally stopped—Mom had gone to bed for the night, and the house was still again. Standing beside the dark green laminate counter with the snow piling up against the dining room window glass behind us, Katie wrapped her arms around my neck for one more long, warming hug until the chill left my fingers.

"Let's use my bed tonight," I whispered as we started walking up the stairs together. "This way we can see the street from my window when we wake up in the morning."

"Sure," Katie smiled. "I hope we wake up to snow on the ground like there is right now."

At the top of the landing, I paused outside my bedroom door and looked at her. “Real quick, if you’re going to spend the night with me: what should we do about getting changed?”

“I’ll go change into my warm pajamas in my room and grab my pillow, and I’ll knock when I’m ready,” Katie whispered with a practical nod.

Three minutes later, after I had pulled on my own heavy winter flannel pajamas and climbed under the covers by the window, three quiet knocks sounded against my door.

“Cartoons are for life,” Katie whispered from the hall.

“Come on in,” I whispered back.

Carrying her pillow under her arm in her purple fleece pajamas, Katie crossed the carpet and climbed under the heavy blanket right at my side. Outside my bedroom window, the Blizzard of ’96 howled silently across Virginia Beach, piling deep drifts against the curb under the glow of the streetlamp, while inside the warm perimeter of my bed, my twin sister and I fell fast asleep holding hands.

Katie Is Dumped

No More Fighting & The Dinner Dance Promise

Date: 1997-10-16 at 16:15 America/New_York

4:15 PM — Tears Under the Blue Butterfly

Middle school had a way of taking kids who had been inseparable since birth and trying to pull them into two completely separate orbits.

For the first month of seventh grade, while I spent my afternoons quiet in my room with my *Nova 64* video games, Katie had tried her hardest to fit into the normal middle-school social script—eating lunch with the girls from her English class and going out with a seventh-grade boy named Donnie. And because both of us were stressed out by the louder hallways, the changing class bells, and Mom’s drinking getting worse at home, the two of us had fallen into the stupid habit of bickering over small things whenever we passed each other in the upstairs hall.

On Thursday afternoon, all of that stopped the second I walked up the stairs and heard the sound coming through Katie’s bedroom door.

Katie was crying up a storm—deep, ragged sobs that echoed right through the hollow wooden door into the hallway.

I dropped my backpack by my door and stepped into her room to check on her and see what was wrong.

Katie was standing near the foot of her bed against the bright magenta-purple wall beneath her framed blue morpho butterfly print, her shoulders shaking inside her dark navy t-shirt and her hands pressed over her face.

“Leave me alone,” she sobbed, turning her head half away when she heard my sneakers on the carpet. “You’d never understand.”

I didn’t walk out, and I didn’t snap back the way a typical middle-school brother would have. Stepping quietly across the room, I placed my hand gently on her shoulder.

“What is it?” I asked softly.

Katie continued sobbing for several seconds, her chest heaving as she tried to catch her breath. I realized immediately that this wasn’t a small hallway argument—this was serious. It took her a long moment to realize that I wasn’t going to tease her or make fun of her for crying.

Slowly, she lowered her hands from her tear-streaked face.

“Donnie dumped me,” Katie choked out, fresh tears spilling down her cheeks. “I loved him, and he dumped me!”

I reached my hand out to gently wipe the tears from her eyes. Never having had a girlfriend myself—and never having been dumped—I didn’t fully understand the mechanics of middle-school romance, but I didn’t need to understand romance to see how badly my twin sister was hurting.

Katie reached out with both hands and took mine, holding onto my fingers tightly as if she were drowning and I was the only solid ground in the room.

“Please… don’t let go,” she whispered, her voice raw.

I closed both of my hands around hers and held on firmly. Looking straight into my eyes with a sudden, desperate seriousness, Katie asked the question that mattered most to survival in a middle-school cafeteria:

“Will you sit with me at lunch?”

The look on Katie’s upset face told me the only answer she needed to hear—and it was the exact answer I wanted to give her anyway.

“Yes,” I answered without hesitation. “I’ll sit with you at lunch.”

Katie burst into fresh tears of pure relief, letting go of my fingers only to throw both arms around my neck and pull me into a tight hug.

“Thank you,” she whispered against my shoulder.

I could hear how raspy and sore her throat was from all of her crying, so I offered to run downstairs and get her a cold glass of water, but she shook her head and held onto my shirt even tighter. As I wrapped my arms around her waist and hugged her back in the quiet room, I felt something shift permanently inside my chest. All the petty squabbling we had done over the past few weeks felt completely, utterly stupid. Katie didn’t want to stop hugging me, and I didn’t have a single problem with that.

“Please, no more fighting,” my sister sobbed softly into my shoulder.

“I understand,” I promised, resting my chin against the top of her blonde hair as we continued to hold onto each other.

“I’m still upset, but thanks for this,” Katie murmured a minute later as I felt a few more warm tears soak into the shoulder of my maroon t-shirt.

“Katie, I’m here for you,” I told her. And as I said the words out loud, squeezing my arms around my twin sister, I realized just how much more I loved hugging her and keeping her safe than arguing with her.

5:00 PM — The Pretend Date & PB&J Sanctuary

When her crying finally began to subside, the two of us sat down side by side on the edge of her green-and-gold patterned bedspread, our shoulders pressed together and our hands still linked.

“Thank you,” Katie said quietly, wiping her eyes with the back of her wrist. “Thank you for being there for me. Someday, I know I’m going to repay this.”

She went quiet for a beat, looking down at our joined hands, before she suddenly whispered:

“Take me to the Dinner Dance this week.”

The seventh-grade Dinner Dance was tomorrow night in the school cafeteria, and half the reason Katie had been crying so hard was the thought of either staying home alone in embarrassment or walking into that room by herself while Donnie was there.

“Of course we can go together,” I said immediately, knowing I didn’t have a date of my own—and wouldn’t have wanted to go with anyone else even if I did. “Even though you’re my sister, we will go on a pretend date.”

“Oh, thank you. Thank you,” Katie breathed, the last of the heavy sobs finally leaving her chest as she leaned her head against my shoulder.

“Would you like it if I made you dinner tonight?” I asked, deciding right then and there to start playing my part as her protective pretend boyfriend.

“Let’s just have something simple, like sandwiches,” she said softly.

“Alright,” I replied, giving her hand a gentle squeeze as the two of us stood up and headed downstairs together.

In the quiet kitchen, I made us both thick peanut-butter-and-jelly sandwiches and poured two tall glasses of cold milk to soothe her sore throat. After we finished eating at the table, Katie looked across at me.

“Could we watch a movie together?” she asked.

“Sure,” I replied warmly. “Let’s pick something together.”

We walked back upstairs to my deep-blue bedroom, picked out our VHS tape of *House Guard 2: Lost in Manhattan* from the shelf beneath my television stand, and pushed it into the VCR. As the opening Majestic Studios credits began to roll across the CRT screen, Katie kicked off her shoes and climbed into my single bed right at my side, resting her head on my shoulder and pulling the blanket across our legs.

Near the end of the movie, when the closing music faded in, I glanced down and saw that my sister was fast asleep against my arm, her breathing slow and completely peaceful after an afternoon of crying her eyes out.

I reached carefully for the remote, clicked the television off, and decided right then to let her sleep. I decided that I would tell her that I didn't mind after we woke up in the morning. Katie was exhausted, and the last thing I wanted was to see her become a grouch because she was woken back up without enough sleep. Part of me marveled at how natural it felt sharing my narrow bed with my twin sister again—just like we had during the Blizzard of '96 and on the downstairs sofa bed at Christmas. We had chosen this close brother-and-sister bond together, and enjoying the warm, quiet company of the person who mattered most to me in the world, I slid down onto the pillow beside her and let myself drift off to sleep at her side.

The Pretend Boyfriend & Twins' Day

Twin Brothers Always Stay: Spirit Week & The Living Room Sofa

Date: 1997-10-17 at 07:30 America/New_York

7:30 AM — "Twin Brothers Always Stay"

The next morning, when the pale autumn sunlight filtered through the blinds of my bedroom, I woke up first—and sure enough, Katie was still fast asleep right at my side in the small bed.

"Katie," I whispered softly, gently prodding her shoulder so I wouldn't startle her in case she didn't realize right away that she had fallen asleep in my room the night before.

My sister stirred against the pillow, blinking her blue eyes open in the quiet blue room before looking from the wall to me in mild surprise.

"Morning, sleepyhead," I whispered with a small smile.

"I slept in your bed?" she asked groggily, rubbing her eyes.

"Yep, and I did not mind," I replied, looking her straight in the eye. "Let's play a game together."

For the first time since Donnie had broken her heart yesterday afternoon, Katie's face lit up with genuine excitement. While she sat up against the headboard, I slipped out of bed, walked across the carpet to the television stand, and powered on my *Nova 64* video game console. I was still in full protective-brother mode, determined to keep cheering her up until I heard her laugh again.

Before I picked up the controller, I turned back to face her.

“I’m your brother. I will always be here for you. Promise,” I told her, my voice steady and earnest in the quiet room. I paused for half a beat, then added the truth I knew we would live by for the rest of our lives: “Boyfriends come and go, but Twin Brothers always stay. Always.”

Before the console title screen had even finished loading on the CRT television, I found myself wrapped in Katie’s arms again. She stood up from the edge of the mattress and hugged me with everything she had, making it unmistakably clear that she had no intention of letting go of me. She held onto my shoulders while the video game rolled through its opening demo sequence on the screen behind us, then sat down on the carpet right at my side.

“We should probably get dressed,” Katie said after a moment, glancing down at her wrinkled shirt from yesterday. “Guess I will pop into my room real quick. Leave the game on this screen while we get dressed?”

“Sure,” I replied, gently ushering her to the bedroom door. “I’ll open my door when I’m dressed.”

8:00 AM — Spirit Week: Twins’ Day

Five minutes later, after I had pulled on a clean maroon short-sleeve t-shirt, medium-wash blue jeans, and my tan sneakers, I opened my bedroom door. Katie walked right back in from across the hall—and the second I saw what she had picked out of her closet, I had to grin.

Without planning it, she had put on the exact same shade of maroon short-sleeve t-shirt and medium-wash blue jeans with a dark belt.

“Next week is Spirit Week at school,” I said as she stepped into the room. “Want to have a little fun on Twins’ Day, since, well, we *are* twins?”

Katie giggled as I handed her the second black controller from the floor stand. “Yeah, we are twins! Wonder how many others will really be twins compared to how many will do it just for fun.”

We both laughed out loud at that remark, and right there in front of my computer desk and television stand, we stubbornly made up our minds.

“I think it’s settled, then,” I declared. “We will dress exactly the same, and we will enter the contest.”

We laughed again, already looking forward to seeing how the teachers and our classmates would react to actual fraternal twins walking into the Spirit Week Twins’ Day assembly dressed identically and holding hands.

“Too bad we don’t have matching shoes,” Katie remarked, looking down at her grey-and-red sneakers next to my tan ones.

“Ah, well. Still, let’s do what we can. I think these pants and shirts look close enough,” I said, setting the controllers on the desk and pulling her into another tight, standing hug in the middle of the room. Both of us laughed into each other’s shoulders, our matching maroon sleeves wrapped around each other’s backs. Yesterday’s tears were completely gone.

5:30 PM — Macaroni & Cheese on the Living Room Sofa

Later that evening, after spending the afternoon practicing our co-op levels and getting ready for the weekend, Katie and I walked downstairs and decided to sit together on the tan-brown living room sofa, curling up side by side while we waited for dinner to be made.

As usual in our house, Dad was in the kitchen working over the stove after a full day at his job, while upstairs Mom was already passed out drunk in bed behind her closed door.

“Mac and cheese is what I smell,” I whispered as Katie slid flush against my right side on the sofa cushions, draped her left arm warmly around my shoulders, and rested her right hand across my forearm to hold me close to her.

“Our favorite,” she replied softly, resting her cheek near my shoulder as the two of us sat there, happily snuggled up together beneath the blue-framed underwater painting on the living room wall.

We had a few quiet minutes to ourselves before the timer on the stove went off, and neither of us wanted to get off the sofa. After years of feeling like we had to keep our guard up against loud classrooms and the unpredictable storms upstairs, snuggling together on the couch felt like the safest, most comfortable place on earth.

As we sat there in the warm glow of the living room lamp, Katie whispered, “Snuggling up is just so comfortable.”

“It is,” I replied quietly, leaning into the warmth of her arm around my shoulders. Neither of us moved an inch; we were both completely content holding onto each other and letting the rest of the house fade away.

A few minutes later, Dad stepped to the doorway of the dining room with a pot holder in his hand, looking over at the two of us curled up together on the couch before calling us in to eat.

When we sat down side by side at the dining table over our steaming bowls of macaroni and cheese, Dad looked across the table at the two of us, his tired eyes softening with genuine gratitude.

“I really appreciate that you both don’t fight and argue with each other,” Dad said quietly, his voice heavy with emotion. “Honestly, I wish your mother didn’t drink her life away. I want to do my best to not only be your father, but also be a proper dad to both of you. Your mother’s drinking is not your fault, and I don’t want either of you to think that. Please don’t let your grades suffer because of it.”

Underneath the edge of the dining table, Katie reached her hand over and laced her fingers tightly through mine, and I squeezed right back. Whatever happened upstairs, and whatever happened in the hallways at school, my twin sister and I had our sanctuary—and we were never letting go.

Sixteen & Summer Sanctuary

Bonding With My Sister

Summer Sanctuary: Hearthstone Pizza, The Sunlit Valley, & Katie's Room

Date: 2001-06-18 at 08:30 America/New_York

8:30 AM — First Full Day of Summer

"Summer is here," I said, blinking open my eyes as the warm June sunlight filtered through the blinds of Katie's bedroom.

"Our first full day with the house to ourselves," my sister replied softly as we started waking up.

Having both turned sixteen back on April eighth, the two of us were curled up side by side in our pajamas on top of her green-and-gold patterned bedspread beneath the framed blue morpho butterfly artwork hanging on her magenta-purple wall, completely used to being pretend dates and full-time anchors for each other. With both of our parents already gone for their morning shifts and two quiet weeks stretching ahead of us before Summer School started, the entire house was finally calm.

Katie rubbed her eyes, then looked over at me and asked, "Get dressed and have breakfast?"

"Sure, I am getting hungry," I replied, giving her hand a quick squeeze as I climbed out of bed.

I stepped across the upstairs hallway into my own deep-blue painted bedroom to pull on a clean maroon crew-neck t-shirt and jeans while Katie changed in her room, and two minutes later we met right back at her doorway, exchanging a warm, familiar smile before making our way down the stairs together.

"Let's just have some cereal, then we will figure out what we want to do for the day," I said as we reached the bottom landing. "I want to spend the day with just you."

Our stomachs were calling us, as was our daily routine of taking our morning dose of medication before the day got underway. In the quiet kitchen, I pulled two ceramic bowls out from the cupboard and set our morning medication tablets beside

two glasses of water while we picked out our cereal from the pantry—being twins, of course it was the exact same box—and sat down at the kitchen table, pulling our chairs right up against each other so we were as close as possible.

After we took our morning medication and started on our cereal, my twin sister reached across the table, took my hand, and looked straight into my eyes.

“What would you like to do today?” Katie asked.

“I was thinking of snuggling on the sofa over a movie,” I suggested as we continued eating our breakfast side by side.

“I know just the movie I want to watch,” my sister said, squeezing my hand. She gave me that unmistakable look like she had a big secret and started giggling. She wanted me to ask what movie it was, but after sixteen years as her twin brother, I knew she wouldn’t tell me—I would have to wait and see what it was when she popped the tape into the VCR.

Since I had made breakfast, Katie took it upon herself to carry our bowls and spoons over to the counter and load our dishes into the dishwasher.

“I will get the tape, then will join you on the sofa,” Katie called over her shoulder as I headed toward the living room.

“Alright, Katie,” I replied, settling onto the cushions of our tan-brown living room sofa beside the coffee table, where Dad had neatly stacked the computer programming textbooks he had checked out from the Virginia Beach Public Library to get a head start on his upcoming fall semester at the Community College of Hampton Roads—CCHR. Over the past few weeks, Katie had started reading Dad’s library books cover to cover and teaching the programming exercises to me, and when Dad found out, he had beamed with pride and actively encouraged both of us to keep coding.

Even better, when Summer School started in two weeks, Katie and I weren’t going because we were behind. We had intentionally signed up to knock out an academic credit over the summer so that when our main high-school year started in September, our schedules would line up with a free period and lunch block together every single day. Until those summer classes began, I was looking forward to having unbroken time with my twin sister.

9:30 AM — *Hearthstone Pizza & Journey to the Sunlit Valley*

A minute later, Katie walked into the living room holding a familiar white clamshell VHS tape behind her back, slid the cassette into the VCR beneath the television, and walked over to sit on the sofa right next to me.

Immediately, she lifted her arm and made it clear she wanted me to snuggle up in her arms. I slid flush against her side and rested my head against her shoulder, glad that I got to curl up with Katie now that the two of us had become so close.

Across the room, the CRT television flickered to life. My eyes lit up as the sweeping orchestral welcome theme to one of our favorite companies—*Majestic Studios*—played across the screen, and then my eyes lit up even further as the previews transitioned and I recognized the exact childhood VHS movie that my sister had put on for us: *Journey to the Sunlit Valley*.

“I knew you would like it,” Katie whispered, resting her cheek against my hair as she looked down into my eyes.

“Of course,” I whispered back with a grin as the tape rolled through its iconic opening bumper before the feature presentation—the familiar, upbeat birthday party commercial from *Hearthstone Pizza* where the older brother was supposed to be nice to the little girl.

We happily stayed curled up together on the cushions as Sprout and his friends began their journey across the screen, wanting nothing more than to sit there quietly in each other’s arms watching the movie. Both of our parents were away at work, the house was completely peaceful, and we had decided that all we wanted was each other—just brother-and-sister time together in our sanctuary before Summer School was set to begin.

9:00 PM — Katie’s Room Beneath the Blue Butterfly

By the time evening rolled around and the June twilight faded outside the living room windows, we had spent the entire day side by side without a single argument, a single raised voice, or a single interruption from the outside world.

As we walked up the stairs together after dinner and paused on the second-floor landing between my blue-painted bedroom and her magenta-purple bedroom, Katie turned to me and took my hand.

“Share a bed?” Katie asked softly.

“Sure,” I replied without hesitation. “Your room or mine?”

“How about my room tonight,” Katie suggested with a gentle smile.

After I stepped into my blue room to brush my teeth and change into a comfortable t-shirt and flannel pajama pants, I crossed the hall and knocked lightly on Katie’s door. Inside her room, under the warm amber glow of the bedside lamp and the framed blue morpho butterfly on her wall, we climbed onto her bed together, propped our pillows against the headboard, and pulled the green-and-gold covers across our legs. Katie draped her arm around my shoulders and laced her fingers through mine, and as the house settled into quiet around us, we drifted off to sleep side by side.

End of Summer Cruise

Part 1: Part 1: The I-95 Haul, The CCHR Library Books, & The Last Straw

Date: 2001-08-22 at 14:00 America/Puerto_Rico

2:00 PM — Coding vs. Ballet & The Knockoff Mascots

None of the three of us—not Dad, not Katie, and not me—had wanted to go on this seven-day Caribbean cruise at the end of August.

Katie and I had worked hard through our summer school class in July, getting a required high-school academic credit out of the way early so that our fall schedules would open up for a shared lunch and free period together. All we had wanted for the final two weeks of summer was to stay home in Virginia Beach, sit side by side in our rooms, and keep working through the computer programming books that our father, David Prairie, had checked out from the Virginia Beach Public Library to get a head start on his upcoming fall semester at the Community College of Hampton Roads—CCHR.

When Dad had first caught Katie and me reading his library programming manuals at the kitchen table back in June—with Katie deciphering the syntax and teaching the logic loops to me on my desktop computer—he hadn't been annoyed that we had borrowed his study materials. Instead, he had lit up with pride and started actively encouraging both of us to follow our dreams.

Our mother, Brenda, hadn't cared about Dad's CCHR classes, our summer school credit, or the fact that walking long distances was already getting harder on Katie's and my legs. She had insisted on booking a seven-day Eastern Caribbean cruise out of Port Canaveral, Florida—forcing all four of us into the family Holt sedan for a grueling twelve-hour drive down Interstate 95 South while Katie, Dad, and I grumbled the entire way to Florida.

Worse, when we pulled into Port Canaveral, we had driven right past the gleaming navy-and-gold hull of a *Majestic Cruise Line* ship docked at the premier terminal across the channel, only to board a bargain-rate mass-market vessel called the *M/S Sunward Tropics*. For four straight days—from the departure out of Florida through Nassau and down toward St. Thomas and St. Maarten—Mom had spent every waking hour running up the stateroom bar tab while treating Katie and me as if we were six years old on one hand and completely able-bodied on the other.

On Wednesday afternoon at sea, Dad finally collected Katie and me outside the Deck 8 arcade and led us over to a quiet row of deck chairs out of the wind.

"Please be honest," Dad asked, looking straight at the two of us with tired, earnest eyes. "Are you two not enjoying the cruise?"

Katie and I glanced at each other, struggling to come up with a polite answer. Both of us had cerebral palsy—something that had affected our balance and coordination our entire lives, even before the deeper, unexplained heaviness had started creeping

into our arms and legs over the past few months—and four days of bracing ourselves against the constant roll of a cruise ship deck had left our calves aching and our shoulders stiff.

Before either of us could speak, Dad leaned forward and rested his elbows on his knees.

“I want to let you both in on how I feel,” Dad said gently. “Katie, this especially goes for you. I watched you teach your brother the programming that I am learning in school at CCHR, and I am absolutely encouraging both of you to keep at it if you both like it. I see that your mother is trying to talk you into being a ballerina, but I get that you don’t want to.”

“I don’t have the balance to dance,” Katie said honestly, looking down at her sneakers. Because of our cerebral palsy—and the way our legs had been trembling even worse lately—standing on her toes at a ballet barre was physically impossible, no matter how stubbornly Mom pretended she had two perfectly typical, non-disabled teenagers. “I like this coding thing.”

“And I am encouraging you with this coding thing… I am encouraging both of you,” Dad said firmly.

“I didn’t appreciate that Mom tried booking us on the kid stuff,” I added, the frustration of the past four days finally spilling out. That morning, Mom had tried to shove the two of us into a noisy elementary-school breakfast event with the ship’s bargain-bin foam mascot costumes—*Barnaby the Buccaneer Parrot* and *Salty the Starfish*. “Katie and I are sixteen and already in high school, and I don’t want to meet the characters. It’s not even the characters that little kids want to meet, because it’s not *Majestic Cruise Line*! I want to play the computer games.”

“I get it,” Dad said, nodding with quiet resolve. He took a slow breath, his jaw tightening. “There is something else I wanted to confide in both of you, and that is Mom’s drinking issue. Our next stop will be the front counter where I want to attempt to cut off the flow of alcohol to your mother.”

2:45 PM — Guest Services & The Soda Package

We walked down the midship stairs to the Deck 5 Atrium Lobby—Dad automatically slowing his pace on the steps as he noticed how tightly Katie and I were gripping the brass banister with both hands just to keep our knees from buckling on the moving ship.

At the long curved counter of the Purser’s Desk, the process seemed to drag on forever. Katie and I found a padded bench across the lobby and sat pressed shoulder-to-shoulder, holding hands while we watched Dad speak quietly with the Assistant Purser and then the Beverage Manager. Because cruise ships operated on cashless plastic stateroom keycards—and because Dad’s *Anchor Federal Credit Union* card was the sole guarantee on our cabin’s Master Folio—Dad had the legal authority as the primary account holder to revoke all charging privileges on Mom’s card and have the Purser place a mandatory intoxication lock on her passenger profile across every bar terminal on the ship.

Twenty minutes later, Dad walked back over to our bench holding three small holographic soda-cup stickers newly affixed to his, Katie's, and my plastic cabin keycards.

"I bought the three of us a soda package, and we can get sodas and juice every fifteen minutes," Dad told us, handing us our cards. "Your mother is going to be mad, but I don't care. I am so sorry to both of you that it is turning out like this, but I have to protect both of you."

Dad sat down beside us for a moment and lowered his voice to a gentle whisper.

"I know that you two have decided that you are inseparable, and I am okay with that, and I won't tell the world about your little secret," Dad whispered, looking warmly from Katie to me. "Yes, I know, and I think I've known for a while. Just don't go blabbing to everyone, and be careful with things."

3:30 PM — "A Cruise for Three"

From the atrium lobby, the three of us walked down to Deck 4 to drop our things off in Stateroom 4118.

In a standard four-person inside cabin on the *Sunward Tropics*, the room was barely wide enough to walk past the foot of the main bed where Mom and Dad slept. Along the side wall sat the three-cushion convertible sofa that the cabin steward unfolded every evening into the double bed that Katie and I shared.

When Dad swiped his keycard and pushed the cabin door open, we stopped dead in the doorway. To our horror—though not to our surprise—our mother was passed out cold, sprawled diagonally across the cushions of the sofa that was supposed to unfold into Katie's and my bed, an empty glass tipped on the carpet beside her shoes.

"Oh, I've had enough of your mother's nonsense," Dad said, his voice shaking as he immediately stepped back and turned Katie and me right around in the doorway.

We walked away from Stateroom 4118 down what felt like an endless, claustrophobic maze of narrow metal passenger hallways. As the ship pitched gently in the Caribbean swell, my right foot caught on the carpet seam and my knee nearly gave out; Katie reached out with both hands to steady my elbow, only for her own left leg to tremble against the bulkhead wall. Walking behind us, Dad saw both of us stumble and saw the strained, white-knuckled effort it took for our arms to pull ourselves upright along the corridor handrail.

When we finally reached a quiet, carpeted stairwell seating alcove at the forward end of the corridor, we sat down on the built-in bench—and right there under the brass ship sconces, Dad buried his face in his hands and absolutely lost it, breaking down and crying.

Katie and I froze, completely at a loss for words. For sixteen years, Dad had been the steady, unshakable rock who went to work, attended night classes at CCHR, cooked macaroni and cheese when Mom was passed out upstairs, and kept the house

from falling apart. Watching our mental image of Daddy being invincible come crashing down—and seeing the exhausted, heartbroken human side of our father for the first time—left a lump in my throat so big I couldn't breathe.

Katie and I sat pressed against his sides on the bench and waited, holding onto each other's hands because this was something neither of us knew how to fix.

"I guess it will have to be a cruise for three," Katie whispered to me, her eyes shining with tears.

"Yeah, I guess," I whispered back to my sister. We both looked over at our father, who was more upset than we had ever seen him in our lives. I didn't even remember crying this hard when taking a bad fall on the sidewalk when my legs gave out, and yet here the three of us were in the middle of the Caribbean Sea.

"I'll try my best to handle this. Daddy needs us right now," Katie whispered, resting her free hand gently on Dad's trembling forearm. "This is going to be a long and painful cruise."

Right at that moment, a furious, echoing screech tore down the metal stateroom hallway behind us.

"The heck was that?" I asked, my shoulders flinching as a startled Katie looked up beside me.

"Where is my fucking beer?!"

Our mother had woken up from her drunken nap on our sofa, walked up to the nearest deck bar, discovered that her keycard had been locked out by the Purser's Desk, and tracked us down the corridor—drunkenly screeching at the top of her lungs at our visibly upset father.

Dad wiped his eyes with the back of his wrist and stood up straight in front of Katie and me, placing himself squarely between our mother and our bench. His voice didn't shake anymore.

"I've had enough, and so have the kids," Dad said clearly. "This cruise was supposed to be family time, and the three of us are tired of your drinking. Nathaniel, Katie, and I are giving you a choice: us, or the alcohol."

Mom stood swaying in the narrow corridor, glaring at the three of us before slurring a bitter, unintelligible string of words that none of us could even understand.

Dad looked at her for a long, quiet second, then nodded once.

"Message received," Dad said flatly. "You pick the bottle over your husband and children."

Turning his back on her, Dad looked down at Katie and me and held out both of his hands to help us up from the low bench—supporting our elbows when our stiff legs wobbled on the rise.

"Come on, you two," Dad said gently. "I want you to show me what you two would like to do."

As our mother drunkenly stumbled away back down the corridor in the opposite direction, Dad led Katie and me toward the forward elevators. With one arm around Katie's shoulder and the other steadying mine, he made a solemn vow to the two of us.

"I'm making both of you a promise," Dad said quietly as we walked together through what felt like an endless hallway of cabins until we finally stepped out into the bright light of the atrium lobby. "I want to be a dad, and I want you both to help guide me through this. It will be painful, but your mother does not seem to want to be a mom. I'm sorry, but I have to do right by both of you."

Part 2: Part 2: Back on Dry Land — The Divorce Lawyer, The PCP, & Borrowed Time

Date: 2001-08-25 at 08:30 America/New_York

8:30 AM — Back on Dry Land

By Saturday morning, when the *M/S Sunward Tropics* tied up at the pier in Port Canaveral and the gangway doors finally opened, the three of us couldn't get off the ship fast enough.

Walking down the steep, ribbed-rubber incline of the disembarkation ramp into the Florida customs terminal, Katie and I held onto each other's inner hands while gripping the aluminum railing with our outer hands. Even after a full night's sleep, my knees felt like they were filled with wet sand, and I could feel Katie's fingers trembling against mine as her ankles wobbled on the slope. Dad carried all three of our heavy duffel bags over his shoulders so neither of us had to bear the extra weight, watching our feet closely every step of the way down to the concrete floor.

Outside on the palm-lined sidewalk by the terminal pickup curb, breathing in stationary, solid-ground air for the first time in a week, Dad set the bags down by our Holt sedan and turned to face the two of us.

"Nathaniel. Katie. I'm sorry that your first cruise was wrecked, and somehow I want to make it up to both of you," Dad said earnestly, resting a hand on each of our shoulders. "Here is what we will do: neither one of you wanted to go on that cruise, but your mother insisted. I want to finish school at CCHR so that I can do a better job at being a dad without having to worry about money as much."

Before either of us could answer him, an angry, ragged screech echoed across the concrete baggage drop behind us.

"You! You told the ship to stop my drinks!"

Our mother had finally stumbled out of the terminal doors behind the last customs line, her face flushed red in the humid Florida sun as she stormed up to the curb after spending the final three days of the voyage locked out of every bar on the ship.

Dad didn't yell back at her in front of the crowded terminal. He didn't waste a single breath arguing. Instead, he calmly unlocked the doors of the Holt sedan, helped Katie and me settle side by side into the back seat where we could lean against each other for the drive up Interstate 95 North, and made up his mind right there on the pavement.

Monday, August 27, 2001, 10:15 AM — Two Phone Calls in Virginia Beach

True to the promise he had made us in the ship's corridor, the Monday morning after we got back to Virginia Beach, Dad didn't wait.

While Mom was still asleep behind her closed bedroom door upstairs, Dad sat at the kitchen table with the yellow pages and the telephone receiver and made two appointments back-to-back. The first was with a family law and divorce attorney off Independence Boulevard to begin the legal process of ending his marriage and securing custody of Katie and me.

The second appointment—scheduled for ten-fifteen that very morning—was with our Primary Care Physician, Dr. Evelyn Chen, at her family practice clinic in Kempsville.

All during the seven-day cruise and at the interstate rest stops on the drive back from Florida, Dad had been quietly watching something that Mom had refused to see for years. Mom still looked at Katie and me and insisted she saw two completely healthy teenagers who were just being "lazy" or "clumsy" whenever we stumbled—which was why she had kept nagging Katie about ballet. Dad, however, had seen the way our arms shook when we pulled ourselves up the ship's stairwells, the way we had to brace our shoulders together just to walk down a long hallway, and the way my legs had nearly folded on the disembarkation ramp.

Inside Exam Room 2 at the clinic, Katie and I sat side by side on the crinkly white paper of the padded exam table in our t-shirts and jeans, our inner hands laced tightly together between our knees while Dad stood right beside the counter.

"Squeeze my fingers as hard as you can, Nathaniel, and hold it for five seconds," Dr. Chen instructed gently, holding two fingers of each hand out in front of me.

I squeezed with everything I had. For the first two seconds, my grip held firm—and then, despite every signal my brain was sending down my arms, the strength in my forearms and wrists visibly faded out. Right beside me, when Dr. Chen repeated the exact same grip and resistance test on Katie's hands, shoulders, and ankles, the exact same drop-off happened.

Dr. Chen stepped back, lowered her reflex hammer into the pocket of her white coat, and looked first at Katie and me, and then directly at Dad. Her expression had gone very quiet and very serious.

"David," Dr. Chen said carefully, "you did the right thing bringing them in today."

"We've known since they were little that they both have mild cerebral palsy," Dad said, his voice tight with concern as he rested a protective hand on the back of Katie's shoulder. "That's always affected their balance. Why are their legs and their arms getting weaker now?"

“That is the exact reason I am concerned,” Dr. Chen explained gently. “Cerebral palsy is non-progressive. The brain injury that causes cerebral palsy happens at or before birth—it does not degenerate over time, and it does not cause sixteen-year-old teenagers to start losing motor strength in both their arms and their legs over a matter of months.”

In the quiet exam room, Katie’s fingers tightened around mine as fast as her tired hand would allow.

“What does that mean, Doctor?” Dad asked quietly.

“It means that either something else has been hiding underneath their cerebral palsy diagnosis all along, or a second, progressive neuromuscular condition is now active in both twins,” Dr. Chen said softly, looking at Katie and me with genuine compassion. “At the rate their lower-limb endurance and upper-body strength have changed since last year’s physical, I need to be completely honest with all three of you: when it comes to walking unassisted, Nathaniel and Katie are on borrowed time. Eventually, their legs are not going to be able to support their weight.”

The words hung in the fluorescent-lit air of the exam room: *borrowed time*.

Neither Katie nor I let go of each other’s hand. If anything, hearing Dr. Chen say out loud what our muscles had been whispering to us all summer—that we weren’t crazy, that we weren’t clumsy, and that our bodies really were changing in the exact same way at the exact same time—made us lean our shoulders even closer together on the exam bench.

“I’m ordering a comprehensive blood panel, nerve conduction studies, and a full genetic neuromuscular workup today,” Dr. Chen continued, writing rapidly on her chart. “As soon as those test results come back from the lab, we are going to find out what is truly happening to Nathaniel and Katie, and we are going to get both of them the equipment and support they need before either of them takes a dangerous fall.”

“Do every test you need to do,” Dad said without a second’s hesitation, his hand resting steady and warm across our shoulders. “Whatever it is, the three of us are facing it together.”